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by Nny11

Summary

The fall of the Healing Horde's Workshop and rise of the Hunter's Dream.

The Workshop

Entrapta, just as many others did, had left Mystacor and the Prospector's for the Horde. There was simply no other place to be for those who desired the bleeding edge of science and knowledge. She was young, yes, and at first she was treated as such. It was Hordak, Lord Prime's little brother, who first noticed her skills with weaponry and had requested her assistance by name. Many had thought it queer, and some of her friends had even warned her that he may want something precious in return for his favor.

At the time she hadn't understood they meant that Hordak may have been a sexual predator of some kind. He was kind and polite and fascinated by her mind and thoughts, and never once did he initiate any physical contact with her. Sex itself was never discussed and never performed, and Entrapta had come to deduce Hordak himself was about as uninterested in such pleasures as one could be. It was a bit of a shame really considering the crush that she developed for him over time, but with all her observations in hand Entrapta made sure to repay him in kind and not press for physical intimacy.

After all, she was equally fascinated by his mind as well. The body could wait well enough in light of that.

When she was still a child, she learned many hands-on skills from him. The forging of weapons, the basics of firearms, maintenance and upkeep. Hordak had eventually told her of an idea he had to turn a simple farmer's scythe into a sword that hadn't worked out, but it lodged in her mind and itched there for several weeks before she made her first attempt. With the inside and outside of the scythe sharpened she developed a crude but effective trigger that allowed it to swing open and closed. When she presented it, Entrapta learned that Hordak had not meant that it could transform between the two states of being.

But he loved what she had made.

They tweaked the design further until eventually the scythe was either a one sided sword, or would extend fully into its more recognizable form. The trigger was refined, the locking mechanisms enhanced, and the weapon tested thoroughly by Hordak himself to ensure the safety of future users. It was crude but effective, and in Entrapta's eyes that made it beautiful.

And Prime? He loved their invention so much that he gave them a small home tucked away in the cathedral's ward to repurpose fully into a workshop.

The workshop grew exponentially in production, they would invent a trick weapon and others would forge the pieces, then they would assemble them for distribution. Expanding from farmer's tools to giant hammers, axes, and swords, specialty blades and guns as well. Eventually having to move production of the simpler items to the Church's main factories and production centers to make enough time for their ever expanding experimentation.

And all had been well.

Until the accident.

Hordak had left with Lady Weaver for an expedition underground, something Entrapta always asked to do but had been categorically denied. Each time it stung, feeling like a reminder that her age alone and inexperience in the field was preventing her from communion, a frustration soothed by the fact that one day she would have what was needed to delve. And it had felt no different that day. It was so boring and normal that she was still unsure what she'd done while he'd left. All she knew was that a girl a few years younger than her had slammed through the workshop doors, huffing and puffing for air, to tell her that Hordak was with the Choir of Light. He wasn't expected to survive. The soon to be hunter, Scorpia, had then escorted her to the surgery theater where Hordak was being worked on and stayed with her for hours there, both of them watching nervously among the small crowd not to learn medicine but to pray for his survival.

Entrapta would eventually learn from Weaver herself that Hordak had been wielding one of Entrapta's newest inventions, the stake driver, and due to the newness of it he left himself wide open to attack. One injury leads to further exhaustion and distraction and leads to another injury in a terrible spiral. This mistake had culminated into several missed attacks before Hordak was been thrown bodily through a stone wall. Weaver was too injured to be in the surgery, but had cautioned her to prepare for the worst.

In a way it was unnecessary, as Hordak survived the attack despite how different and ineffective blood healing had been at the time.

But in a way she was also right, as he was never quite the same.

Bound to his wheelchair, Hordak became taciturn and volatile. Entrapta quickly put away her more explosive and esoteric weapons and instead worked with him to redesign some of the best and safest options into something even better. It had helped, but not by much. Her Hordak, kind and reticent and confident in turns, was gone.

And to top it all off, Glimmer and Bow arrived shortly thereafter and were half assigned to assist them both.

Some days she wished they hadn't come at all.

Captain Glimmer was equally pompous as she was caring, naive as she was cynical, brutal as she was hopeful. She had arrived from across the lake, if her accent was anything to go by, and she had not come empty handed. She'd given Entrapta a blade from her home, she called it a chikage and demonstrated its unique abilities with the user's own blood. Entrapta had been fascinated by the way the hunter's blood could enhance their attacks. It was a risky sort of weapon, requiring injury to use to its fullest but the potential it held outweighed many of the standard offerings Entrapta had worked with for years.

Hordak had scoffed at it entirely, belittled the captain and her weapon before returning to the house. It felt like an attack on herself for having been interested. Entrapta had begged his forgiveness, to no real avail, and then the Captain's as well. Entrapta had offered to tinker with her strange and beautiful weapon as an apology for this foreigner's hurt pride and to slake her own curiosity. What Hordak didn't know surely couldn't hurt him, not in this matter.

Entrapta had worked in secret while Hordak slept or attended the choir, and eventually her newest weapon, the rakuyo, exceeded everyone's expectations. Captain Glimmer was enamored with her double sided sword as much as she delighted in her ability to split it into a short sword and knife. It had felt good to work with someone who expressed their joy and excitement so freely. In fact, Captain Glimmer had been so pleased that she then begged for Entrapta's help for her good friend.

Captain Bow was too kind and soft for the Horde, that was what Entrapta had heard whispered among the halls at least. He was considered foolish and dull, but upon meeting him she couldn't fathom why. Bow was very clever, resilient, and possessed a good sense of humor which was a reprieve to hear among the sea of dour Hordesmen. When he and Scorpia got on a roll it was a sight to behold and Entrapta often felt filled with energy afterwards.

She'd been more than eager to assist him if she could, and Bow expressed a fondness for wordplay as he'd explained how he detested firearms. Guns were loud and drew beasts in, but also ruined ambushes and limited what a hunter could do. The quality of the pistols and blunderbusses, and even some cannons, had reduced when they left the workshop floor for production. The boring process was not as neat and precise, sometimes skipped entirely leading to shorter ranges and worse accuracy. Bow had not been able to get enough power from the blade he used for larger beasts, and had been forced to take a blunderbuss to compensate. Bow had seen their saifs and cane whips, and wondered if a blade could be turned into a bow with enough power to compensate.

Once again, where Hordak would have once found great fascination in the challenge, he instead dismissed it as foolish and berated the young hunter for his pride. Entrapta kept her tongue still until he'd wheeled himself back inside the house to work once more on the "standardized but enhanced" weapons that Lord Prime requested.

So, once more, Entrapta had worked in secret until a crude trick weapon was ready. Bow himself loved it, and then revealed his own interest in tinkering and trick weapons, and together they improved her first pass into something more functional, and then eventually into the Bowblade. A beautifully curved sword that, with only the smallest flick, could be transformed into an extremely powerful bow, one with enough power to stagger nearly any beast.

She had been ecstatic. Too happy and excited by their creation to notice the slight creak of Hordak's wheelchair as he came out to see who had invaded his sanctum now.

When Hordak found them, she feared his wrath. He'd only hit her once, but it had a lasting impact. At minimum she expected him to rage and shout and destroy various tools about their floundering workshop. As if Prime was not disappointed by their now stale and stalled productions and refinements. As if the Horde's hunters were not sneering in their appraisals of the quality unaware or uncaring of the source. That day he had almost killed the good captain when he threw Bow into the open elevator shaft leading to the workshop before rounding on her. She had nervously approached, trying to explain herself and hoping to calm his rage so he wouldn't set them back even further with his destruction- and he had slapped her.

They had both stared at one another in shock for an endless moment. Then Hordak's face became unreadable before he slowly wheeled himself away.

After that Entrapta had been willing to let him destroy anything he pleased, as long as his rage did not turn on her again.

Many things changed that day, none of them things she could understand, none of them things she could draft and create and build away.

Hordak began to cry in his sleep at night, sometimes her hands shook during the day when they spoke, something between them had broken and shifted painfully with no clear indication of what.

Entrapta could not fix emotions any more than she could pause time to catch up on their newest batch of demands from Lord Prime. So she made a choice, a fatal choice, to show him what he meant to her instead. Words had never been their forte, so she was confident that her gift would succeed where she had failed.

Hordak did not bother them when one of the Captains came to visit now, merely shutting the doors to the house to block them out. The freedom to spend more time as she saw fit was his apology, and Entrapta made use of it.

Scorpia was a wonderful sounding board, and Glimmer was excellent for checking on practicality, but mostly Entrapta worked with Bow on what she was determined to make her greatest invention yet. There were many former hunters like Hordak, who's injuries had not killed or changed them, only putting them into wheelchairs or losing them their limbs. The mobile chairs were slow and bulky, hard to maneuver without someone to push them. The prosthetics were too delicate or too unwieldy. She had a plan to help **all** of them. Starting with Hordak.

First, a smaller chair. Something lighter and more agile. Sure the large heavy rifles many of them carried were not well suited to it, but the ever effective flamethrower was! For missing arms or missing hands she found ways to connect one to a harness with a trigger at the elbow. It was simply a first pass, something to assist quickly and efficiently as the true project began.

Lord Prime found these small and simple items to be unworthy of the Church's material and money. Bow manufactured the prosthetics on the side and Entrapta accepted private payments to

make the chairs in what little free time she had left. Hordak had accepted one only because his was falling apart from neglect, but he seemed to loathe it even more.

That was fine, because she was already working on The Project!

An exoskeleton to help him walk again, powered in part by a small furnace and in part by arcane powers and a smidge with the crystals of the First Ones found in the labyrinth beneath their feet. She needed it to be perfect, she wanted him to love it, and anything that did not meet his ever shifting goal of perfection was worthless. Entrapta worked in secret, testing rudimentary parts with Bow before realizing she needed to fit it more properly. Glimmer had half joked and half sneered, "Perhaps he'll let you pose him like a doll!"

A doll. A life size doll *would* be helpful wouldn't it? But only for fitting while the device was not in use.

An automaton, however, well now. That could do just right!

Months passed as she tinkered with her automaton. Her new friends encouraged her every step of the way, even assisting her without asking! Glimmer sometimes brought them branches from the woods, one of the few brave enough to venture into its twisting depths, and Bow would painstakingly carve them to the measurements Entrapta provided. Scorpia would return from the catacombs with anything she thought might help, and much of that which didn't could be repurposed. Hordak of course knew she was doing something. Up to something is how he phrased it, but his resignation to it bolstered her efforts. When her automaton was as close to finished as it could be she tried the exoskeleton on it.

"Yeah Wrong Hordak!" Bow cheered while Scorpia clapped as it wobbled but walked thanks to the exoskeleton's assistance.

Entrapta had shrieked with joy, feeling more hopeful than she ever had. Even Glimmer had gotten swept up in the celebration,

all four of them jumping and hugging and frankly carrying on more than they should have. That night after they left, she stayed up late putting the finishing touches on it noticing the soft squeak of wheels far too late.

“So.” Hordak had started, soft and almost conversationally. His eyes wild and sunken, burning with malice so brightly she’d scrambled a few steps back. “This is what you’ve been up to. Not enough to abandon me for a strong, young man. You had to remake me as I was. Do you think me feeble? Infirmed and pitiful?!”

“No!” She twisted her hair in her hands as tears swelled in her eyes. She’d never once thought that, she’d never even considered he might feel that way. “I was-”

“Do you think I’m stupid, then? To not notice-”

“You’re not stupid!”

He’d smiled, thin and cruel and she felt dread pool deep in her chest as he looked right through her. “Do you know the one thing I cannot abide by?”

The **one** thing? Entrpta’s nose scrunched in confusion as she tried to think of an answer that would satisfy his cold rage. There were many things Hordak could not abide by. Imperfection. Untimeliness. Unnecessary messes and sounds. Thieves and liars- oh. “I’m telling you the truth. You aren’t any of those things. This- this was supposed to be a gift. A surprise. If you wanted it.”

Wrong Hordak stood without power, the exoskeleton’s furnace was cold.

Hordak rolled around her, closer to it and for one moment she thought maybe it was working and he was actually inspecting it.

There was a click and a whoosh of air, and long licking flames split the night. Flying from Hordak’s flamethrower onto her creation.

Entrapta screamed with surprise and then despair. That was her only one, that was the only one! Without it- she ducked just in the nick of time as the flames turned on her. Scrambling on her hands and knees to get away, nose filling with the unmistakable smell of burning hair. She stumbled to her feet and ran around the corner of the house, hands beating at the back of her head to put out the smoldering bits as Hordak screamed unnaturally. There was heat around the corner, her night vision was ruined as she tried to pick a path through the twisting front garden by sight. Too many piles of junk and parts that moved daily, if she cut herself on a blade or tripped on rubble, that could be it. He would catch her.

Hordak's screaming turned to laughter as he wheeled around the corner of the house, another spray missing her by inches. "Do you see what you've done!?"

Entrapta whirled around to beg him to stop only to see exactly what he'd meant. In his rage, Hordak had caught the workshop on fire. She stared open mouthed in horror. That was their home! That was their- by all the gods, the amount of gunpowder in there alone! A beam collapsed and smoke poured out. Hordak didn't seem to care as he stopped in front of the main doors. The fire danced in his eyes, silent tears rolling down his face. "You've ruined everything!"

Was this her fault? Was all this… "I- I didn't mean to!"

She barely heard his barking laughter over the raging inferno. "Don't lie to me now!"

There was a bang as the gunpowder store finally lit, the pressure caused the explosion and filled the air with a brief stream of white smoke. Splinters of wood flew out and Entrapta curled up on herself as a larger piece barely missed her throat, lodging instead into the right side of her chest. It hurt, she didn't know how to describe the way it hurt even years after the fact when her scar would sometimes throb. In that moment she could not think, a high pitched ringing in her ears.

The fire burned and, in a way, so did she.

And Hordak had fallen silent.

When she managed to finally pull herself upright, gasping with pain and bleeding heavily, Entrapta watched with that same mindlessness as Hordak's body burned unmoving. Perhaps he'd been too close to the fumes and pull of oxygen, passing out before the fire got him. The explosion could have done it too. He was much closer and the wood could have impaled him or crushed his head. The flamethrower had been filled with oil and fuel too, the heat could have set that off as well, covering him in seconds. There was no way to know, her mind was lost as she stood and couldn't even cry.

Entrapta would have stood there until she died, if she'd had the faculties to make decisions she's decently sure she would have walked into the flames to be consumed by them.

But Scorpia had seen the fire and not gone out hunting that night, many heard the explosions but chose to stay away for their own safety, but the kind captain? She had rushed forth dressed only in a nightgown. Large hands pulled her further back, deftly pulled the wood from her chest, and ignored her scream of agony as Entrapta began to understand what had happened. To understand all she had lost. She howled again as Scorpia plunged the blood vial into her arm, not wanting to live when all was lost. There was a wash of warmth that felt cold against the fire and she was healed, safe and sound in Scorpia's arms. Entrapta looked up at her, trying to understand what was being said, but none of it made sense. Nothing made sense.

She just wanted to make him happy, her closest and oldest friend. Her partner.

Entrapta sobbed, smearing soot onto Scorpia's pale skin as she was pulled closer.

The workshop burned.

And so did that version of herself. Immolated in the flames, her heart replaced with ash.

To Dream a Dream Can Lead to Madness

Chapter Summary

> With the destruction of the old workshop, Force Captain Glimmer can see the writing on the wall. Etheria is doomed if something drastic doesn't change, and change soon.
>
> Perhaps it's time to give up on her dream of revenge.
>
> Or perhaps it's merely time to enact it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She hadn’t been there when the Workshop was destroyed, Glimmer had been out hunting as beasts were beginning to roam the streets outside of the full moon. Bow had the rooftops and she had the street, they spoke as they walked to stave off boredom but also to draw any potential beasts to them, and all had been well. They were excited about Entrapta’s inventions and new iterations. Bow’s excitement came from his desire to help hunters who were disabled gain some freedoms and mobility back, even if they never hunted again. Glimmer had ideas to help grant extra strength and power to more hunters and even more people across the planet, to those outside of Etheria who would still need such protections. Both had become disillusioned with the Healing Horde over the years, but it was still the best option for any hunter.

Even then, she’d had dreams of starting an alliance of hunters, mutual aid and training and resources that wasn’t as wrapped up in the odd religion of Etheria or the supposed superiority of the ancient city’s people. A place any hunter could belong.

Bow had helped her to integrate as best he could, and Glimmer was never shy or hesitant to try any ritual or drink, but her accent marked her as an outsider forever no matter her behavior. Her

weapon marked her as foreign and untrustworthy, even with the improved new weapon Entrapta had made after studying the original blade. Within the ranks of the Horde, she was only one step above a beast to most. It had been a harsh change to her reality but one she'd made in the name of furthering humanity's survival.

(She was homesick in some ways, although her rage at her parents had ensured she didn't do anything too rash or foolish about it.)

So that night, they spoke of inventions and uses and hunters, idle in their dreaming. And it was a beautiful dream too, destined to end as all dreams must.

That horrible crack BOOM filled the silent night, and began their new waking nightmare.

They turned and watched as smoke, first white, then black, poured from the Church Ward. Glimmer had always had an uncanny ability to know directions and locations, so she had gasped in realization first. "Bow, that's the workshop!"

Bow had leapt down to the street as they made their mad dash home, regardless of if their route was finished.

They ran as fast as they could, dodging anyone who dared to peek outside to see what had happened, and rushing past their fellow Hordsemen who watched idly. Only slowing when old Madam Razz waved them down and pointed to a side door neither had ever seen before.

"Dearies, this way, much faster to your friends!"

Madam Razz was a chapel caretaker, her incense a special blend that didn't rely on the dwindling supplies across the city. She always seemed to know something or someone or some way about, but few bothered to listen between her rambling tales. Glimmer could not be more grateful that Bow had forced her to sit and talk with the old woman, otherwise she would have ignored

her outright that night. It was a gift from the caretaker of Sh'Ra's own chapel, and who were they to question such things? They ran through uncaring as it shut and locked behind them, realizing in surprise that they were above the workshop now and could see the sheer destruction of whatever had happened.

"Oh, gods be good." Bow had whispered in horror as he stared.

Glimmer swallowed her fears and growled at the now missing steps that should have led them further down. The boards had either rotted away in the dark, or perhaps the explosion had broken them off. Even the ropes that once held the only elevator access to the workshop had broken. But Glimmer could see the way forward easily enough. "Bow, we need to jump down here!"

"I- how!?" There isn't-"

"We still have legs, jump!" Glimmer dropped down, rolling to alleviate as much pain on her ankles as possible and could only be grateful that he dropped down with her regardless as the smoke she hadn't seen in the gloom nearly overwhelmed her. She barely had taken a few steps away when Bow hauled her back to pull her shirt over her mouth and nose. "There isn't time to slow down."

"And there will be less if you pass out from smoke inhalation." There was a slight snap to his voice from the anxiety, his own mouth already covered by his scarf.

He was right and she hated it. Most of the smoke billowed freely into the air but enough filled the shaft to make it a concern. They carefully picked their way down the scaffolds and laddered their way down as much as they could, emerging out to the courtyard to find Scorpia cradling Entrapta in her arms.

Glimmer could barely make out Hordak's arm from the rubble.

She cared not for the man himself, he had seemed rotten to the core to her, but she did care for her friend who loved him. Entrapta seemed to be in shock, although perhaps it was blood loss based on her clothes.

It was a long night after that, and it was capped with a dreadfully early meeting as Lord Prime requested their presence to learn what exactly had happened because the gods truly hated them all now apparently.

Lord Prime was… Glimmer wasn't sure what to think. His office stank of decay and blood, and he wore a dreadful metal mask with an eerie grin. Her angel blood sizzled and hissed as he cajoled Entrapta into speaking. Hordak had apparently been testing a new flamethrower when they got in an argument, and in his frustration he'd accidentally caught the workshop on fire causing the gunpowder inside to ignite.

Glimmer had looked first to Bow then to Scorpia as Entrapta spoke in monotone to the floor, confirming what she already knew. Entrapta was lying. Whatever the reason, they were in agreement to maintain it.

"My poor, dear brother," Lord Prime had sighed heavily, the hint of something else twisting in his voice, almost layering it in two, "Not the brightest man since his accident, I should have known better and refused his demands to work."

Entrapta's hands twitched at her sides but her face didn't change nor did her voice. "It can be rebuilt."

"No." Prime finally turned to look at each of them in turn and Glimmer could have sworn he smiled behind his mask as he assessed her. "The workshop is done, we have the weapons we need in production. I will have it sealed away, and none are allowed back. I suggest you four bathe and rest."

"I still have-"

A sound, almost like a growl and almost like a hiss and like the clapping of thunder rolled from Prime's chest. So fast that Glimmer would have assumed she mistook the sound, if not for Scorpia's considering look.

“My word is law.” And truly he left no room for argument. “You may leave, ah, but Captain Glimmer, was it?”

Her blood sang in tantalizing waves. “Yes, my lord?”

“Make sure to return and give me weekly reports, I expect good things from all of you.”

“Of course, my lord.”

Glimmer left with one truth from the meeting.

The Horde was every hunter’s best option, and it was pitiful.

Their leader was so drunk with power that Glimmer was quite sure he’d orchestrated the destruction of the workshop to kill his own kin. Their once grand weapons were of lowered quality and stagnated, even as the beasts evolved ever more. Their ranks were filled with cowards and bastards. And the risk of discovery as an “enemy” of both Etheria and the Horde had never been greater. They could only ignore so many orders to kill innocent people showing no signs of infection, so many nights wasted by taking on patrols the others refused, so many days spent on pins and needles and Lord Prime’s Choir slowly retreated into their tower above the new workshop and locked them out. It was still the only choice for those who needed training and gear.

But it was no longer an acceptable solution.

It took great effort to keep an eye on Entrapta and ensure she would not slip to drink or blood or madness after such a blow to her heart. It took equal effort to hunt beasts of sufficient danger and size to please Prime and the Horde, to try and maintain order of some kind with citizens and corrupt hunters from all walks. And still she worked more. She stayed up late to read the books and scrolls and notes Bow brought on the history of the city and hunters. She needed to understand them if her alternative were to have any hope, and Glimmer would slit her own throat before allowing her life’s work to falter.

Etherian hunters may be more open to simply shooting another foreigner with grand designs to help after the damage from Prime. And even though she'd fled her throne as a princess, she was still trapped at the mercy of the newest class of blood thirsty nobles.

To put her efforts concisely: it was a rather bleak outlook and she was sick of it.

Each ward and township functioned independently from one another, their feuds ran deep, and their hunter's served only those within their own jurisdictions. Etherian isolationism at its finest, she'd scoffed to herself. Even when pushed cheek to jowl, they only seemed to tolerate one another due to their ancestry and religion. There was the old Swiddens Ward, largely depopulated but still powerful due to being the last source of horticulture inside the city walls, who seemed to always be in some sort of dispute with the Lower Ward which held the city's cisterns and waterways. And the Lower Wards were in near constant disputes with the Northern Border and Central Etheria as the dead and the beastly remains made its way into their drinking water. And that was without even considering the "towns" that made up each ward, some stacked on top of one another and still bitter about who'd build last! All of them, of course, had more disputes and more alliances, and all seemed to agree to tolerate Mystacor and vilify Brightmoon based on nothing more than sheer tradition. Whatever silly fairy tale she believed about Etheria before, she found a deep frustration that tipped on occasion into hate for it.

And the hunters were no better! Each beholden to their own councils or rogue players with no actual power who inevitably were the only ones putting in the work against the scourge. Many she'd met over the years and most she'd like to forget, but the few who seemed sensible, well, it was an opportunity she couldn't pass up simply because of the backwards ways of the city. If they could simply unite them under one banner, one pale blooded banner to guide them…

It was Scorpia who posed the question and then the answer. "Well where can we go to provide a safe haven, a genuine safe haven

from the beasts? That alone would gain us allies."

"Within the city? Only the workshop seemed free of beasts and even then, it, well-" Glimmer had winced as she glanced at Entrapta, but the inventor didn't seem to be paying attention.

Scorpia winced, lowered her voice but lost none of her signature brightness while lamenting, "Oh, gosh, wouldn't it be wonderful if we could go back? We could build a network of some kind to slip in and out and connect everywhere!"

"Like a hub." Bow nodded slowly as he tried to think on it further.

"Say, Entrapta, didn't you used to study at Mystacor? Is there anything like that in the catacombs?" Scorpia gently patted her shoulder.

Entrapta grunted under the force of it, but was pulled back at least. "In the labyrinth? Hmm, no, I don't think so. It connects to many places but it's more dangerous than the city proper, or at least that I know of. But I know the Provost had been exploring an arcane option as a last resort. The dream of an ancient one can act as a physical space, after all, so the dreams of many mortals could possibly draw a god to dream with them. It was all a lot of theory and debate though, and he was distracted by the possibility of a blood cure."

"It's a dangerous thing to draw the eyes of the gods." Scorpia had said with such conviction and dread that Glimmer had to work to not roll her eyes.

"Does it need a god though, or just the blood of one?" Bow was clearly thinking aloud on the matter, but Glimmer's blood sang.

"Or perhaps it just needs powerful blood of any kind." She spoke slowly, the rough shape of a vision forming in her mind. "Powerful blood with enough people to bolster it further?"

"Well, well I suppose it depends on the power of the blood. But without an ancient one to enter and maintain the dream, it would

be doomed to failure anyways.” Entrapta for the first time in at least a year gained a spark in her gaze. “Are you thinking angelblood could do it? That is what Brightmoon uses, isn’t it?”

Too knowing. Too close.

And yet.

This was her chance, this was her **chance** . Her blood sang and something flashed in the corner of her eyes with the truth of it. “Someone with sufficient levels of angelblood could draw in the interest of an ancient one, without needing one.”

“It could kill whoever tried.” Entrapta cautioned and Bow was too quick to gulp and look at Glimmer, who refused to look back just in case anyone was still fooled by the farce.

“Please, can we speak of something else? I can almost feel the gods gazes and I- ha! I would greatly prefer not to! This calls for a tonic, anyone else want a tonic? I think I’ll make us some!” Scorpia blustered about and any further attempts to speak were halted.

It didn’t take much to find Entrapta wandering the mostly empty halls the next day when most of the Horde slept between hunts.

“How long have you known?”

Entrapta had looked at her, clearly in consideration before that dullness that overrode her most days returned thick and heavy. “Your weapon was quite unique and no one else could gain the fullness of the properties you displayed. It was an educated guess.”

“You won’t tell anyone.” Glimmer had no problem making such demands, even if she had to control her rage at Entrapta’s almost sarcastic smile. “Tell me, what if I channeled it through another, then I could still enter the dream and hold it for anyone else, yes?”

“Hmm, possibly. But you would need to make sure whoever you channel through not only has angelblood of their own, but can withstand the pure magic it would take.” She paused thoughtfully before adding, “you would need to concentrate on the workshop, or, well, what used to be the workshop to make it the location.”

Stars danced and somewhere behind her eyes, Glimmer could hear the faintest of arias.“Why would I do that when it could be anything, be anywhere?”

“Well, the workshop is the closest place I can install a wayward lamp, something to call to the dream in turn so we could enter after you. A portal is necessary for the rest of us. No you so much, you’ll be trapped there forever I expect.”

Her heart clenched at the thought, but she knew from Bow’s books that there were always ways around such requirements. Could she find one in time? It was too many angles but they were running ever more out of time. Beasts were appearing every night now, and even some during the day. Without better tools more and more hunters fell and the Horde was running out of able bodied fighters to press into hunting. It was so bad that they were now using contracts to force foreigners into the fight, those who’s ailments were killing them, those who were desperate enough to trade their soul for their life.

So it didn’t matter, really. If Glimmer had to stay in the dream it just meant she could coordinate from there, even if she couldn’t be on the ground. Perhaps she could get more done that way, ensuring a way for all of them to stay safe and bring more into her fold.

All it would cost was getting the payback she so rightly deserved.

“I know someone who can assist us. Set up your lamp and wait there if you can.”

“Now? Wait, there’s resources to gather, tests to be done-”

“Then do them! Here,” Glimmer tossed her Captain’s badge to Entrapta, “that will get you whatever you need. But we must be done before Prime calls on me next week. Can you do that?”

Entrapta chewed on her lip in consideration before nodding slowly. “I’ll have Scorpia help me. We need crystals and blood on our end too. I- you know she won’t join us, don’t you?”

“She will. In time, she’ll see it’s the best way forward.”

Or perhaps the good captain would die instead. It honestly couldn’t matter to her, what mattered was uniting non-Horde hunters. She would mourn her friend but she would not put one life above the survival of humanity.

“If you say so.” Entrapta mumbled, half distracted and half dismissive.

Glimmer wasted no time. Her horse was requisitioned in record time and before the moon rose, she was long gone.

It was time to pay her father a long overdue visit.

Chapter End Notes

> They are all so close to understanding, but alas, not so fast. All that has been must be once more.

Surreptitious Toil

Chapter Summary

> The spider hides all manner of rituals, certain to reveal nothing, for true enlightenment need not be shared.

It had been many years since Prime had last set foot in Mystacor. He'd wondered, idly in passing, how he would feel should he return. The sight of his greatest triumph, the place that set him on his path. But no. Nothing.

Or at least not from Mystacor itself.

The woman he'd found seemed paranoid, almost jumping at shadows and he wondered what she saw in the darkest corners. Clearly she had still been impacted by the force of the spell even though she'd been far enough away to not be killed outright. He'd seen some like her in the catacombs, driven mad by the little revelations made just for them. Their blood could make for an interesting reagent if harvested quickly, or unique and powerful gems could form as it crystalized over time. He made a mental note to check on Mystacor in a few years time, to see what might arise from her. Seeing her had made him mildly curious.

Seeing her brother had brought him an excitement that had bordered on euphoria.

Provost Micah, the second most powerful arcane user he had ever met, had been hollowed out and something new had taken residence there. The man Shadow Weaver had described as naive, foolish, gullible, and soft was nowhere to be found. Micah sat with a straight back, calm and considering. His fresh wounds scabbing over seemed to not bother him at all, even if they sometimes cracked and spilled small amounts of blood. By itself it painted a most compelling picture. But Prime found himself delighted by the the newest statues in the school.

Twenty seven former students remain twisted in pain and terror wherever they'd been when the spell reached them. The youngest one trapped in the grip of an old woman who pointed towards the door, its little face scrunched up in clear confusion. Another had been up on a ladder to access something from the now empty shelves, and was frozen in the moment they had started their desperate climb. Statues was, perhaps, too evocative of a word. The stone and wood and brick had all turned into basalt, bubbled together and filled with faces if he stared long enough to find them. As if the room had been built around a large and elaborate carving.

And Micah sat at the table, half splintered wood and half rough rock, as if uncaring of the lives lost around him, content to wait Prime out and enjoy his tonic.

Purple glowing eyes met green behind his mask, and Prime smiled wider as he removed it.

"You have seen it now, brother?"

Micah didn't even flinch as Prime's visage was revealed, head tilting in consideration.

"Come now!" Prime smiled as he took up his tea to sip. "There's no need to play coy with me, Provost. I've held your position, I've seen it too- out there beyond the bells."

Micah's voice was rough, his throat still recovering from the ritual. "Have you seen the little ones?"

Prime's hearts moved out of step as he lied through his teeth, "They are the messengers, brother, of course I have."

"The messengers…" Micah hummed. "Ancient Ones, or their kin?"

Ah yes, all of them were doomed to crave a child of their own, and all would be doomed to lose their children. Prime was no different in many ways, but the rotting flesh in his pocket ensured he would succeed where no so-called god had. His ascension

would be just, but until then he still had mortal needs, and right now he needed the good Provost's knowledge.

"Some of them, yes." Conjecture at best. All he needed was an opening. One opening.

Micah turned to look at the woman whose face was forever frozen half asleep and half terrified, the book she'd fallen asleep on sat with the pages rigid in the air from sticking to her cheek.

"Reborn, Provost. Mourn not those who are now healthy babes."

"What do you want, Lord Prime?" Micah did not turn his gaze away, but neither did he react to Prime's jest.

Once more his great intellect and charisma wasted. Ah well.

Prime finished his tea and placed the cup down with care to balance as best it could.

"I come to offer you a trade, brother, knowledge for knowledge. This ritual- I must understand it. And in return, well." He reached into his breast pocket to withdraw the small container. Once it had held cigarettes, now it was the perfect size to ferry one important item. Micah turned slowly, drawn by the sheer arcane power that radiated off of it. Once upon a time such an offer would have been impossible, but now such things were trivial to him. Even without the orphanage, even without his research hall, all had been set in motion and could not be stopped from such a small loss. "I cannot promise you will learn what you wish, communion with the gods is a fickle thing."

"What will you do with it? The ritual?"

Prime's smile widened as Micah carefully plucked the cord from inside it's silk lined case, inspecting it closely. Ah what he would give to see what the man saw now, it must be extraordinary!

"Perhaps you can ask your gods when you partake."

Micah snorted, derisive and cold as he carefully pocketed the dried cord for later. With one wave of his hand a new book rose out of the table, the surface rippled like water and smelled of copper and lightning as the frozen woman toppled into the abyss beneath her. Prime carefully lifted it up to inspect, his own handwriting on the cover writhed in agony.

“Perhaps I will.”

“Excellent. Then I must away, as they say. May the good blood guide you, brother.”

His mask slid back into place smoothly, the sister scrambling backwards to avoid him as he strode out of Mystacor for one last time.

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